

insight ■ workshop

For a painless reinstall

**Need to reinstall
Windows? Here's how
you can avoid starting from scratch**

Every Windows user, at some point or other of his system's life, goes through the agony of reinstalling the operating system. Yet, the real pain lies not in reinstalling Windows—on today's systems, it takes just half an hour to format the drive and install the operating system again. What's tedious is restoring the system to a usable state—getting all the correct drivers for the hardware, installing all applications and tweaking the system, all the while pray-

ing that you haven't lost any data when formatting the hard disk!

But worry not. Help is at hand. We

show you smart ways to ease pain and smoothen out the reinstallation process by saving application settings that will help pick up from where you left off your system crashed on you.



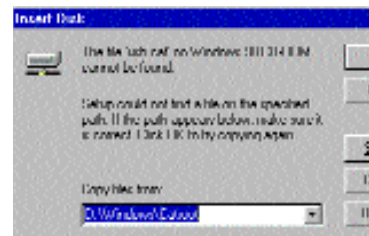
Readme.1st

Given that there are so many flavours of Windows in use today, as well as the variety of applications we use, it is not viable to cover every possible combination in this article. Thus, the article largely focuses on Windows 98, Office 97 and Internet Explorer 5, though alternatives for other platforms are mentioned where relevant. However, application architectures have varied only slightly over the last few versions, so you can generally apply the same rules across different platforms—only some file locations would have changed or some dialog boxes would have been updated. For example, Outlook Express stores e-mail in different locations across different versions of Windows.

After you've installed Windows, the first thing you'll be asked for is the drivers. Though Windows will find most of the drivers for common hardware on the Windows installation CD itself, it will often not get the correct ones for hardware such as the graphics, network, sound and SCSI cards.

If you have your old Windows installed on a different partition or a different folder, installing drivers becomes very simple. Windows stores all driver information files in \Windows\Inf, with the files for third-party hardware in a subfolder named 'Other'. Thus, when asked for a driver, simply point the Hardware Wizard to this folder and it will pick up the correct driver information file. It will ask for a lot of support files (usually SYS and DLL files); these should be located in the \Windows or \Windows\System folder of the older installation. If you can't

Hardware Dri-



Point the Hardware Wizard to the older Windows installation

locate them, they are either on the Windows Setup CD, or in a subfolder System or System32 folders. Use Windows 'Find' (Start > Find > Files or Folders) to locate the required files and again, point the Hardware Wizard to the correct location. Once you have all the hardware installed and your system is up and running, you can connect to the Internet and download the latest updates of all the drivers.